

What the Numbers Hide

A deep read of the TrustMRR dataset — 1,000 startups, beyond the obvious

1,000 STARTUPS · 29 FIELDS · SNAPSHOT: 30 JUL 2026

This isn't a clean dataset — that's the story

Six things immediately jump out once you look past the summary stats

1

Extreme concentration

Revenue isn't spread across the dataset — a tiny sliver of startups own most of it

2

Hype ≠ revenue

The most popular category by headcount is not the most valuable per company

3

Geography gap

Median revenue varies by 200x+ between top countries — not just volume

4

Vanity metrics lie

Follower counts barely predict revenue at all

5

'For sale' ≠ struggling

Businesses listed for sale actually out-earn the rest of the dataset

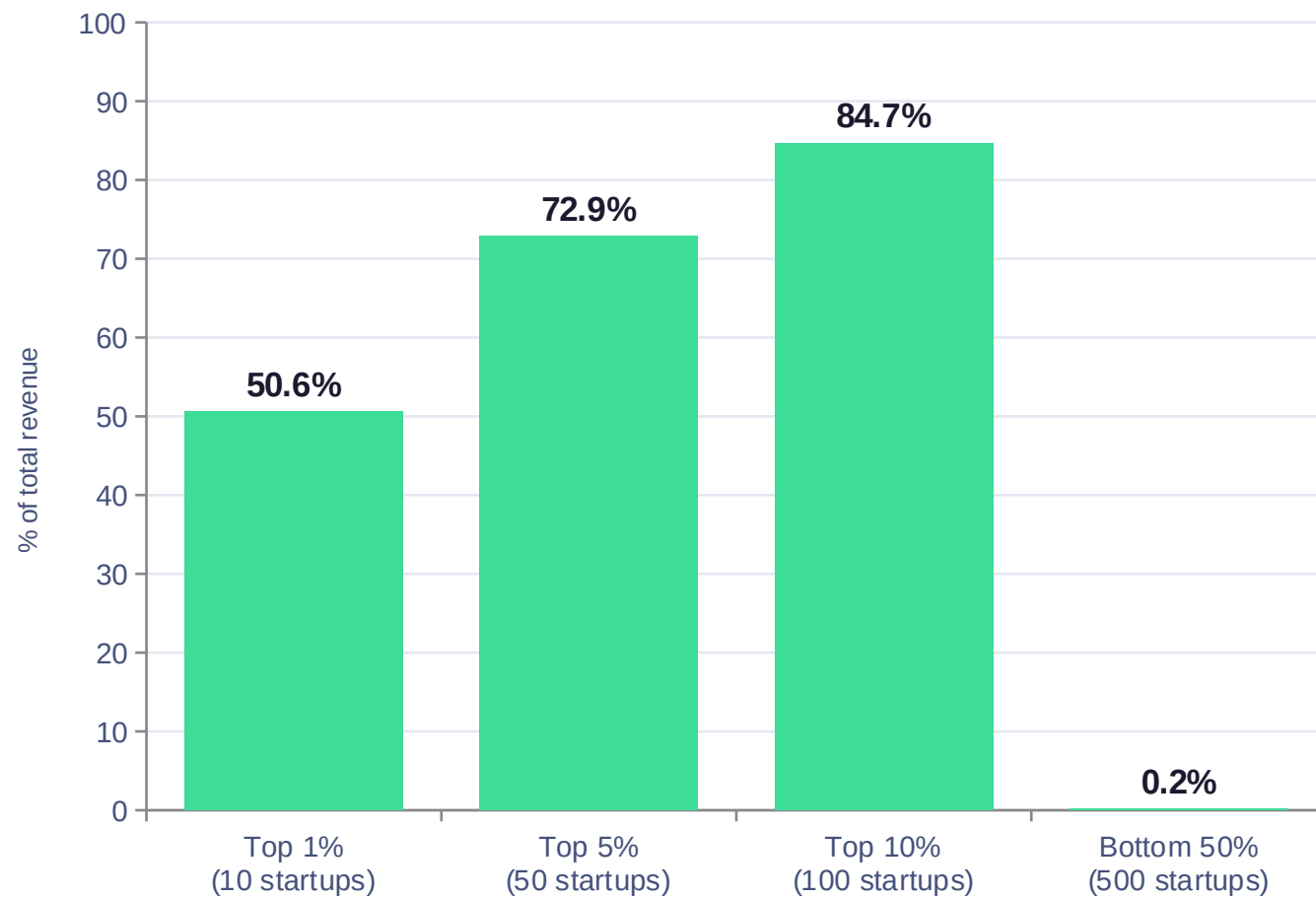
6

The blanks are informative

Missing fields cluster in ways that reveal how listings were built

The Power Law: 10 startups out-earn the other 990

Share of total 12-month revenue, cumulative by top slice of startups



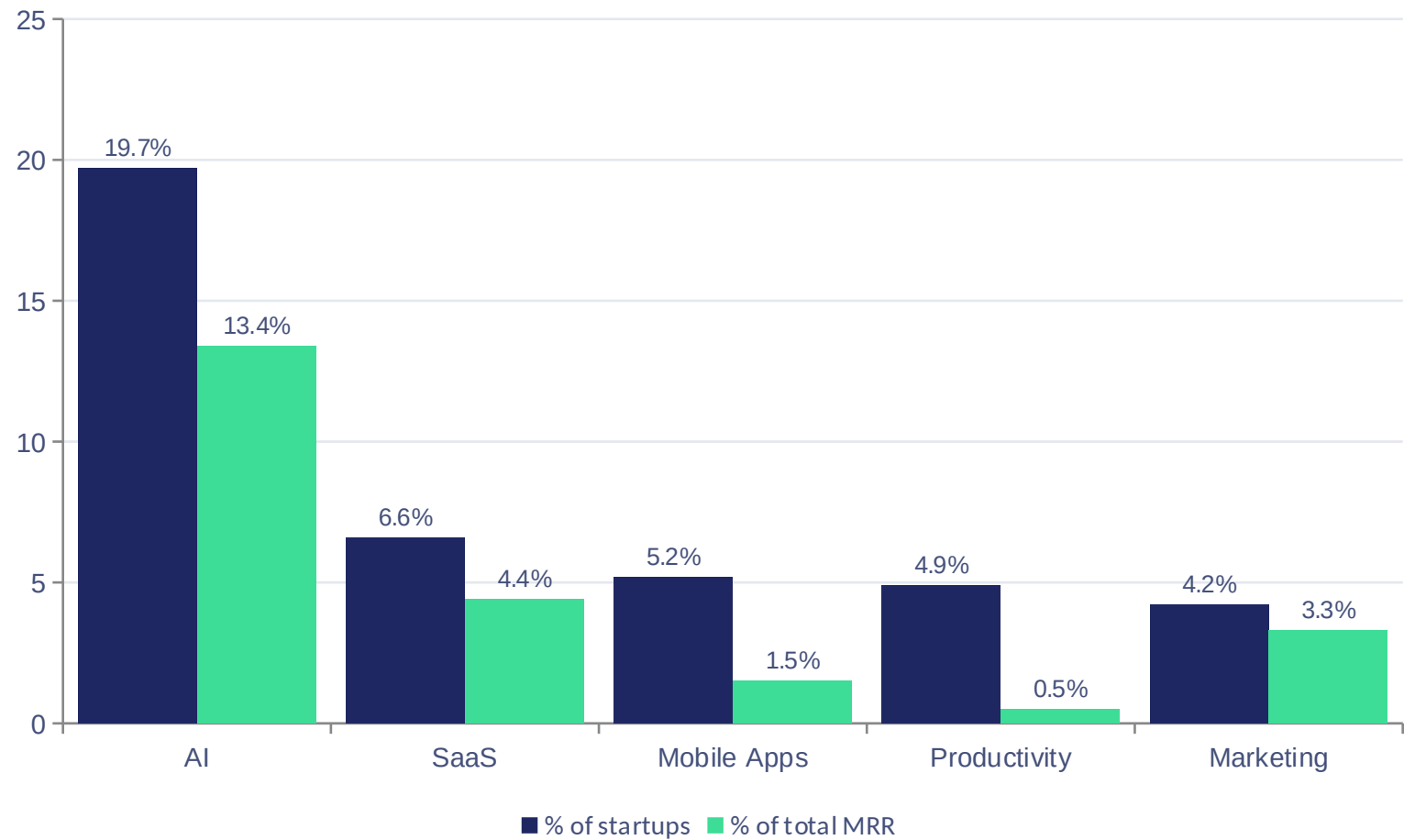
50.6%

of all revenue in the dataset comes from just 10 startups (1%)

10.9% of startups report \$0 in trailing 12-month revenue — pre-revenue or dormant listings sit alongside multi-million dollar businesses in the same dataset.

AI is the most crowded category — not the most valuable

Share of startup count vs. share of total MRR, by category



Reading the gap

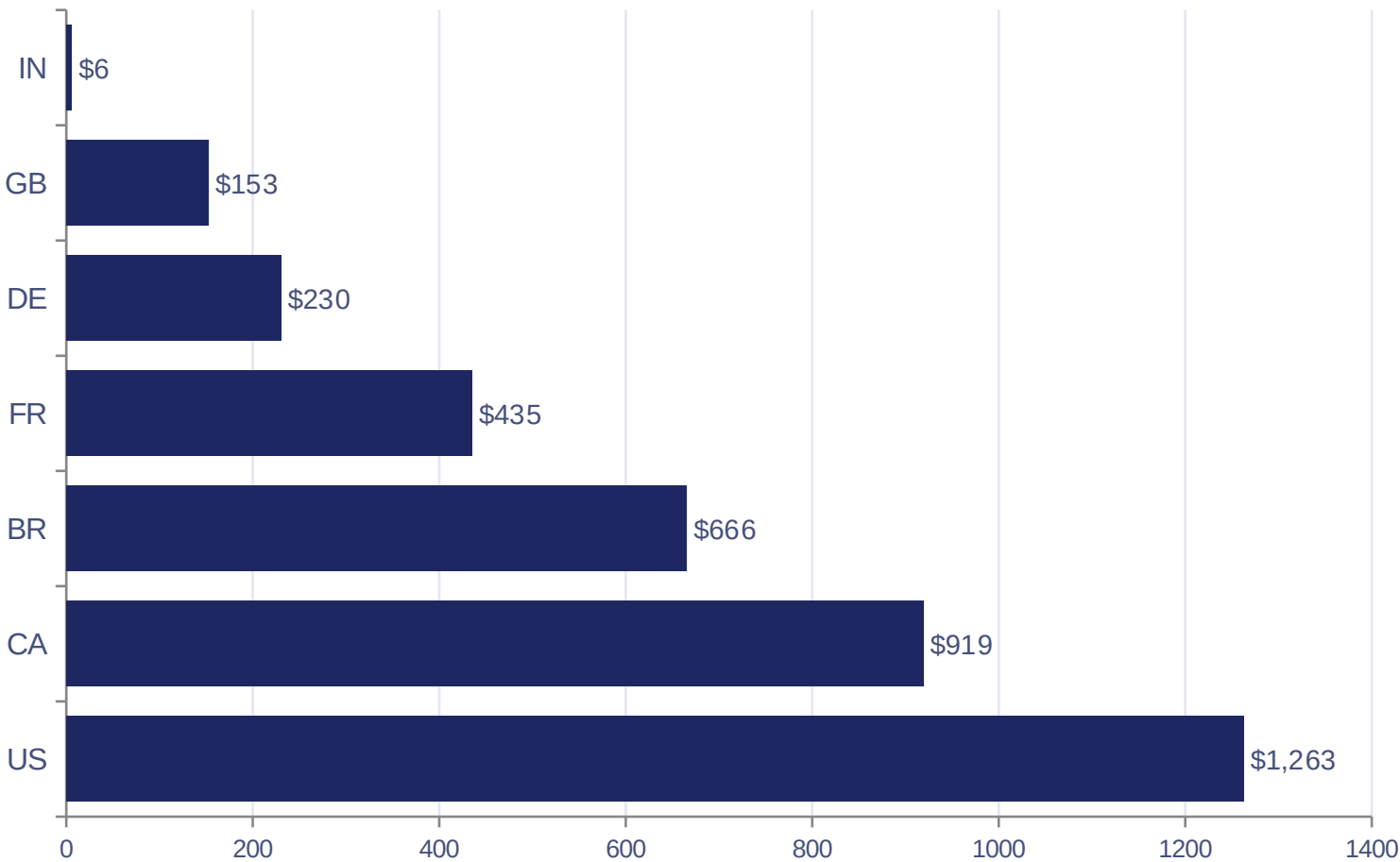
AI: 1 in 5 startups, but only 13% of MRR — heavily crowded, thin margins per entrant.

Productivity: 5% of startups, just 0.5% of MRR — the weakest monetizer of the group.

Marketing: Punches above its weight — 4.2% of startups capture 3.3% of MRR, near parity.

A 200x revenue gap hides behind the country column

Median MRR (USD) by top labeled countries



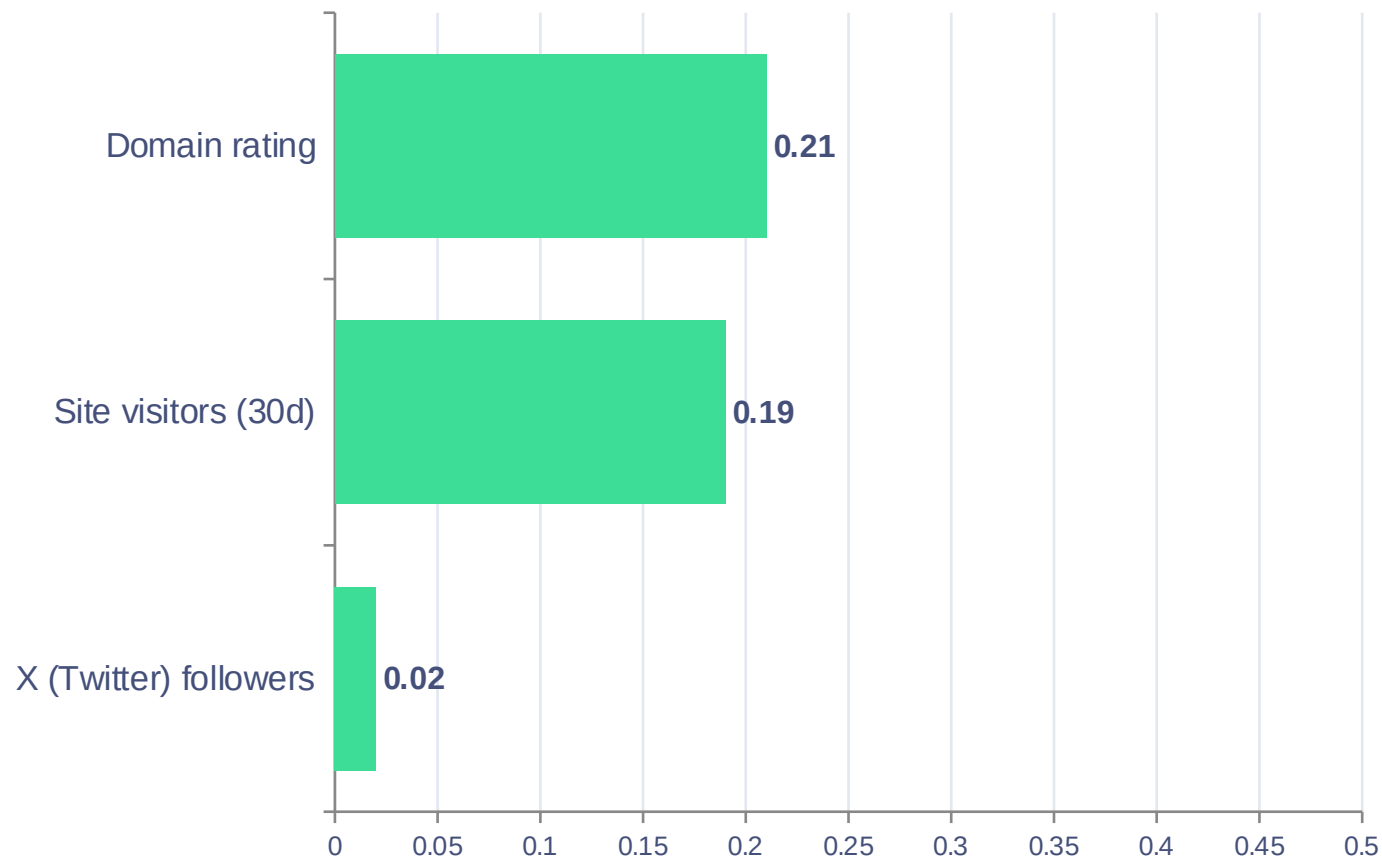
212x

gap between the median US startup (\$1,262 MRR) and the median India-based startup (\$6 MRR) in this dataset

24% of rows have no country listed at all — geographic analysis here is a sample, not the full population.

Followers don't predict revenue. Almost at all.

Correlation of each signal with monthly recurring revenue (MRR)



Why this matters

A correlation near 0 means a huge X following tells you almost nothing about whether a startup actually makes money.

Domain rating and site traffic are weakly positive — real, but far from decisive.

Takeaway: audience size is not a substitute for checking the revenue line directly.

Businesses listed for sale out-earn the rest

Median MRR: startups marked 'on sale' vs. everyone else

NOT FOR SALE (738 startups)

\$187

median MRR

median 11 active subscriptions

ON SALE (262 startups)

\$1,055

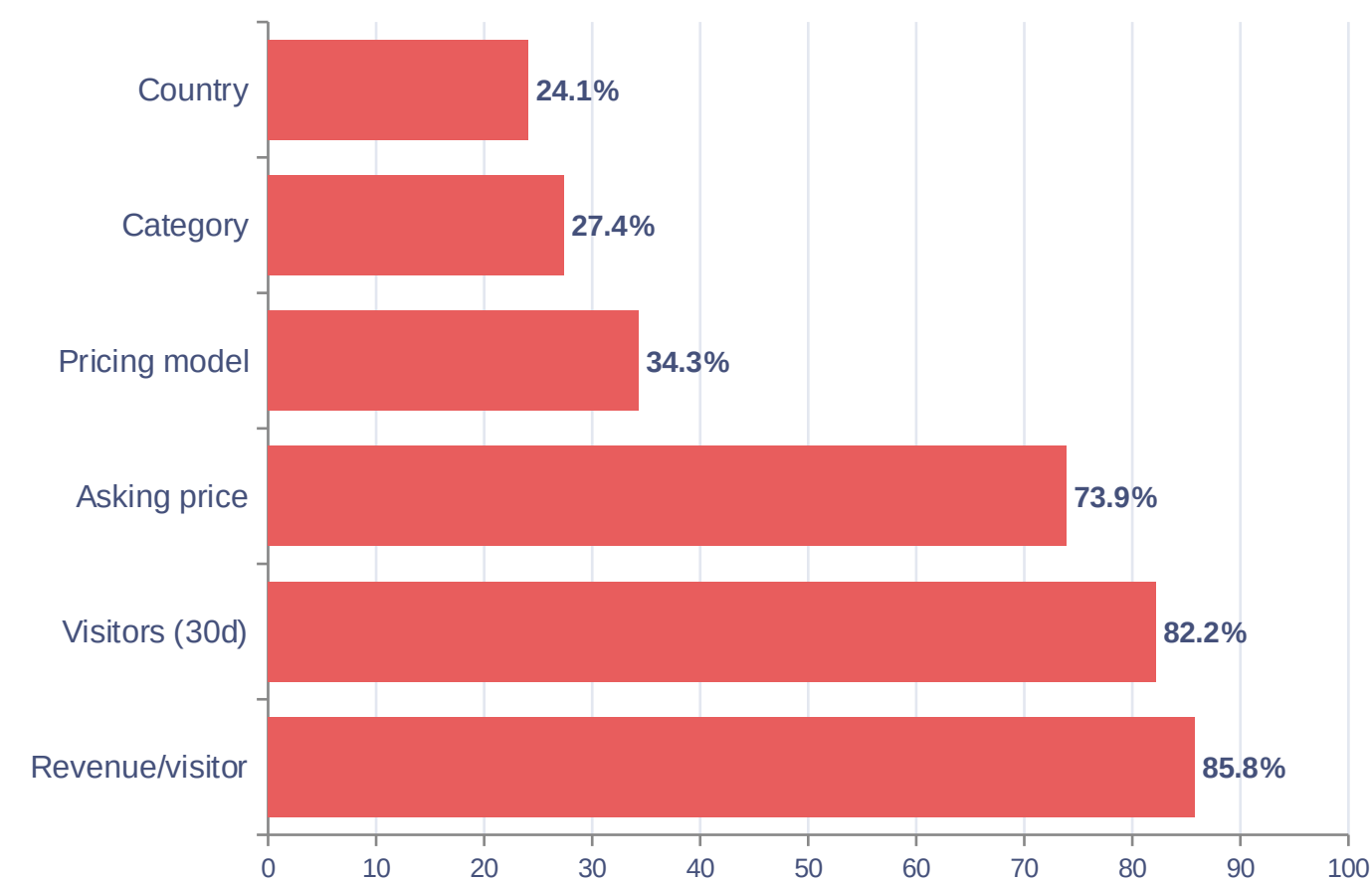
median MRR — 5.6x higher

median 32 active subscriptions

This flips the usual assumption that a listed-for-sale business is a struggling one. Here, sellers appear to be cashing out of healthier, more established businesses — not offloading failures.

The blanks tell their own story

Share of rows missing each field — and what it implies



129 'Stealth Company' listings

88% are missing a category, vs. 27% dataset-wide.

66% are missing a country, vs. 24% dataset-wide.

Anonymized listings systematically withhold more than named ones — missingness isn't random, it's a signal of listing type.

Six takeaways, in one place

- 1 Revenue is a power law — top 1% of startups hold half of all revenue.
- 2 AI is the most crowded category but not the best per-startup monetizer.
- 3 Country matters enormously — median MRR spans a 200x+ range.
- 4 Social following is a weak-to-nonexistent predictor of revenue.
- 5 'On sale' listings out-earn the rest — sellers are cashing out winners.
- 6 Missing data isn't random — anonymized listings withhold systematically more.